

FOR INTERNAL DISCUSSION

DISCUSSION PRIMER

Building Capacity for Indigenous Community Prefabricated Housing

Online Workshop · Tuesday, July 7, 2026 · 9:00 am to 12:00 pm

Hosted by Khelsilem · BC Indigenous Housing Society

A MESSAGE FROM YOUR HOST

Thank you for joining us.

I'm Khelsilem, and I'll be hosting our three hours together on July 7.

This primer prepares you for the conversation. It doesn't hand you conclusions, because there aren't any yet, and that is the point.

What follows is brief. Please read it before we meet, and come ready to speak to three questions:

- What is going well?
- What is challenging?
- What would help?

Bring your real examples, your hard questions, and constructive raising disagreements you might usually keep to yourself.

HOW I COME TO THIS WORK

He served two terms as Chairperson of the Squamish Nation, where housing was central to his work, including the Seṇákw partnership.

He comes to prefab interested in one question: how Indigenous providers can build more homes, faster, on their own terms. He is here to listen as much as to host.

WHY WE'RE HERE

Our purpose, and the outcome we want.

Where this group needs to be by noon.

WHY THIS, WHY NOW

Indigenous communities in BC face a shortage of roughly 50,000 homes. Prefab can build faster and at lower cost, and governments are moving on it. With few exceptions, Indigenous non-market providers have not yet engaged. We're here to change that.

THE OUTCOME WE WANT

A shared, specific picture of what is working, what is blocking us, and what would help most, captured in a report that points to concrete next steps for the sector, funders, and government.

WHERE WE NEED TO BE BY 12:00

A short, prioritized set of opportunities and asks that this group stands behind and that we can carry forward with credibility.

WHAT THIS WORKSHOP IS, AND ISN'T

A working conversation, not a consultation.

WHAT IT IS

A working conversation among people active in the field: providers, designers, manufacturers, project managers, foundations, and the policymakers who fund this work.

A space to share your ideas and engage with other people's ideas.

You're invited as an expert in your own right, through lived experience, traditional knowledge, governance, design and manufacturing practice, or policy.

WHAT IT ISN'T

- A panel discussion.
- A passive presentation you sit through.
- A decision-making meeting. This workshop informs decisions, it does not make them.

YOUR ROLE TODAY

What we're asking of you.

For each part of the day, know whether you're here to share, advise, listen, or decide.

SHARE

Most of the morning.
Bring real examples and
speak from your
experience.

ADVISE

Your input shapes the
recommendations the
report carries to funders
and government.

LISTEN

Hear across sectors and
regions. In some rooms
you'll mostly take in
others' experience.

DECIDE

Not today. No one is
being asked to commit
their organization to
anything.

HOW WE'LL FOCUS

Three questions guiding the day.

01

What is going well in enhancing Indigenous community prefab housing?

02

What do we find challenging in this work?

03

What would help us do more of it, and do it better?

The same three questions run in every room, across both tracks.

HOW WE'LL ORGANIZE

Two tracks, one set of questions.

TRACK A

Sector capacity and practice

The knowledge, tools, partnerships, and shared resources providers need: procurement approaches, digital design, team assembly, and standardized or repeatable designs.

TRACK B

Policy and programs

Changes to federal, provincial, and municipal or local government policy and program design that would speed delivery, especially in financing, procurement, and standardization or bundling.

Each track works the three questions. You will stay in the same group for round 2 and 3.

THE SHAPE OF OUR WORKSHOP

Agenda for July 7 - 9am to 12pm.

TIME	WHAT WE'RE DOING
8:50 am	Virtual Hallway – Zoom Meeting Link Opens
9:00 am	EVENT START: Workshop Start! Welcome
9:05 am	Context Setting with Hosts & Special Guests
9:30 am	DIALOGUE ROUND 1: What's going well in Indigenous community prefab housing?
10:00 am	DIALOGUE ROUND 2: What's challenging in this work?
10:25 am	Report back for Round 2
10:45 am	Brief Break
11:00 am	DIALOGUE ROUND 3: What would help us do more of it, and do it better?
11:25 am	Report back for Round 3 & Close & Next Steps
12:00 pm	Event Close

HOW THE ROOMS WORK

Small Group Discussions

You'll be in small groups for the 2nd and 3rd rounds of discussion. Each group will need to select one person to report back the main themes of their group discussion to everyone afterward.

We'll have note takers in each breakout room.

Have questions? Send them to meeting facilitator Khelsilem through the Zoom chat function!

WHO WE ESPECIALLY WANT TO HEAR FROM

Voices we're counting on.

Those directly impacted

Providers and communities delivering or trying to deliver housing right now, on reserve and off.

Those with hands-on experience

People who have worked procurement, design, manufacturing, financing, or project management on real projects.

Those with a different view

Where prefab isn't the answer, and where local jobs or other priorities matter more than unit cost or speed.

We may ask a few people to open a round so the conversation starts from real experience.

CONTEXT · THE NUMBERS

The scale of Indigenous housing need in BC.

~50,000

units of Indigenous housing need in BC

\$15–20B

estimated capital requirement

20–40%

potential per-unit cost reduction with prefab at scale

POPULATION	PERIOD	UNITS	CAPITAL COST ESTIMATES
On-reserve, current	to 2021	20,000	\$8.2B (2021\$)
On-reserve, future	2022–2040	7,000	\$2.2B (2021\$)
Urban (off-reserve), current	to 2022	20,287	\$5.3B (2022\$)
Urban (off-reserve), future	by 2034	9,696	Not estimated
Combined estimate		~50,000	\$15–20 billion

Caveat: Possible double counting between on-reserve and off-reserve estimates.

Where prefab pays, and where it doesn't.

20%

Federal baseline

Build Canada Homes per-unit cost reduction modelled with prefab.

40%+

At scale

Private developers report this, with roughly half the usual schedule and passive house or zero-carbon performance.

PREFAB IS NOT THE RIGHT ANSWER EVERYWHERE

Where local job creation matters more than unit cost or speed, conventional onsite construction may better fit community goals.

Upstream, there's room for Indigenous forest managers and forestry companies to build value-added manufacturing into their operations, aligning local economic priorities with housing supply.

Part of the conversation is naming where prefab helps, and where it doesn't.

CONTEXT · WHERE IT GETS STUCK

Five barriers in reach. Two set the ceiling.

UPSTREAM · ONLY SENIOR GOVERNMENTS CAN MOVE THESE

Demand → supply

Without sustained, committed demand, manufacturers won't build prefab capacity — and thin supply keeps costs high. The single largest barrier, and only senior governments can move it, through deliberate demand generation.

Policy & permitting

Development approval, inspection timing, and financing milestones are built around on-site construction, and inadvertently penalize factory-built housing.

WITHIN THIS SECTOR'S REACH · WHERE THIS WORK FOCUSES

Procurement

Standard design-bid-build doesn't fit prefab: factory deposits, phased delivery, early manufacturer involvement.

Design

A manufacturing system needs different relationships among architect, provider, and manufacturer — and digital collaboration most haven't set up.

Team assembly

Prefab needs new roles, like a manufacturing liaison and transport logistics, and different team configurations.

Standardization & bundling

Semi-standard designs, produced in succession or bundled across providers, are the largest unrealized lever on cost and time.

Knowledge

Most providers haven't built the expertise to navigate the four above. It compounds each — and is the most fixable here.

Building well, and building low-carbon.

Sustainability isn't a trade-off against speed and cost. At scale, the three can move together.

Performance

Offsite production supports passive house and zero-carbon performance, with tighter quality control than many onsite builds, reducing long term operation and maintenance cost.

Less waste

Factory conditions cut material waste and site disruption, and shorten the time crews spend in the community.

A shared priority

Lower emissions align with community stewardship and with funder and government climate commitments, including our partnership with the Zero Emissions Innovation Centre.

CONTEXT · WHAT'S ALREADY MOVING

The ground is shifting in our favour.

FEDERAL

Build Canada Homes

Names prefab as a route to lower per-unit costs and faster delivery, with cost reductions modelled in.

PROVINCIAL

BC's prefab moves

Look West names offsite manufacturing an economic priority. The Construction Innovation Action Plan is advancing. The Building Permit Hub is streamlining digital permitting.

RIGHTS

The Declaration Act Action Plan

These efforts intersect with provincial commitments under the Declaration Act, including items on Indigenous-led housing and economic self-determination.

CONTEXT · SOME IDEAS ALREADY ON THE TABLE

Starting points, not conclusions.

From pre-workshop conversations. Sharpen them, replace them, add to them.

Indigenous offsite pre-construction guide

A practical reference for non-market developers.

Workshop series

Digital permitting, alternative procurement, integrated design teams, standardized designs, CSA A277 factories.

Community of practice

Sustained peer learning across the sector.

Procurement innovation policy paper

Directed at provincial and federal decision-makers.

Co-developed semi-standard designs

Replicable across multiple Indigenous housing providers.

First-cost financing mechanisms

Capital during materials and factory production, not only on conventional draw schedules.

BEFORE YOU JOIN

Before July 7.

01 Reflect on the three questions

- **What is going well** in enhancing Indigenous community prefab housing?
- **What do we find challenging** in this work?
- **What would help us** do more of it, and do it better?

Read this primer. Thinking it through in advance helps everyone take part. Bring preliminary ideas; the discussion will sharpen them.

WHAT TO EXPECT NEXT

Synthesis, report, and attribution.

WITHIN 2 WEEKS

Draft synthesis

Two to three pages of the key themes, sent to all participants. A real chance to give feedback, refine, and correct.

WITHIN 4 WEEKS

Full workshop report

Brings in the synthesis and ongoing input, submitted to BCIHS and the funders. Participants receive a copy directly.

Attribution. Discussions are under the Chatham House rule unless the group decides otherwise. Themes may be shared externally; named attribution requires your consent.

PARTNERS AND FUNDERS

Who's behind this work.

LEAD

BC Indigenous Housing Society

FUNDERS

Canada Mortgage and Housing Corporation · Real Estate Foundation of BC · North Family Foundation · Zero Emissions Innovation Centre

WORKSHOP DESIGN, FACILITATION & REPORTING

Khelsilem, in collaboration with Boston Consulting

We look forward to your contribution on July 7.